

one, or none. You may make big bucks or chump change. It doesn't matter. Somewhere, sometime, you're going to reach your personal career plateau. When you get there, some people will be higher than you and some lower. In this sense all managers are middle managers. Even a chief executive feels he's in the middle, sandwiched between customers, suppliers, stockholders, directors, government, and the organization's needs.

Remember the bathtub test? I learned it early in life—after toilet training but before I learned that “nice guys finish last.” The bathtub test goes like this: “Fill a bathtub with water. Put your fist in the water and then pull it out. The size of the hole you leave is how important you are.” I remember doing the bathtub test as a kid. I remember being almost surprised by the obvious fact that there's no hole at all. I felt like crying. “I'm not worth *anything*?”

I finally realized I *am* worth something, to myself and to my family and friends. But in the larger scheme of things, the bathtub test holds. I remember hearing a talk by Reginald Jones when he headed General Electric. After his formal remarks someone asked, “How many employees do you have at GE?”

Mr. Jones's reply, as best as I can recall, was, “Three hundred eighty thousand.”

“So do you think there's any slack in there?”

Mr. Jones laughed. Indeed there was slack in there. People could leave, even hundreds of people could leave, and GE would continue its course without the slightest waver.

We tell ourselves the company might make more mistakes without us. We convince ourselves that we're indispensable. We can't say that about anyone *else* in the company. The boss could leave, the boss's boss could leave, and their replacements would be just as good or better. *We're* the only indispensable ones. We shove the bathtub test to the back of our minds, along with other ideas like “go visit Aunt Margaret” or “stop smoking.”